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Writing to the Judge: A Character Letter Guide

For the people who want to speak up for someone they love.

Before sentencing, a judge often reads letters from the people who know a defendant. A good character letter can help the court see a whole person, not just a case file. This guide is for family, friends, employers, and mentors who want to write one. It explains what helps, what hurts, and gives you a shape to follow.

Send letters through the defendant's lawyer, not directly to the court, unless the lawyer tells you otherwise. The lawyer will make sure they arrive the right way at the right time.

What a good letter does

- Speaks from your own honest knowledge of the person, with specific examples.
- Shows their character through real stories, not just adjectives.
- Acknowledges the seriousness of the situation without arguing the law or the facts.
- Is respectful, brief (usually one page), and clearly your own voice.

What to avoid

- Do not argue that the person is innocent or attack the case. That is the lawyer's job, and it can backfire.
- Do not minimize what happened or blame others.
- Do not exaggerate or say things you cannot stand behind.
- Do not ask for a specific sentence unless the lawyer guides you to.

A simple shape to follow

- Open: who you are, how you know the person, and for how long.
- Middle: one or two specific stories that show their character, their role in others' lives, their work, their kindness.
- Acknowledge: that you understand this is a serious matter.
- Close: what you know to be true about who they are and who they can be.

Prompts to help you start

A specific time this person showed their true character:

Who depends on them, and how:

What you most want the judge to understand:

Practical notes

- Handwritten or typed both work. Sign it and date it.
- Include your full name and how the court can reach you if needed.
- Give it to the lawyer well before the sentencing date.

This workbook is educational and reflects lived and professional experience. It is not legal advice and does not create an attorney-client relationship. Laws and procedures vary by jurisdiction and change over time. For advice about your situation, consult a licensed attorney in your state.

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